

The expert committee report

To plan its future, Prasar Bharati, the Indian broadcaster of public radio and television, constituted an expert committee in January 2013, under the chairmanship of Dr Sam Pitroda, advisor to the Prime Minister of India on Public Information Infrastructure and Innovations. The committee submitted its report to the government on January 24, 2014.

The committee has endorsed the use of DRM for the digitisation of the radio network and has recommended that analogue medium-wave (MW) transmitters be converted to DRM to increase audio quality and content/channels. The committee has recommended that analogue and digital broadcasts may continue until 2016 and be completely converted to digital after that.

Realising that the receiver ecosystem for digital broadcasting is going to play a crucial role in the early absorption of this technology, the committee has indicated that it is necessary that the demand for the production of low-cost receivers is built rapidly. The committee has indicated that this demand can be built only by bringing multiple players in the service delivery. It has recommended the participation of private vendors in order to increase competition, to give a variety of content and to bring the cost down for the receivers.

The emerging opportunities

Over the years, the form factor of the radio receivers has dramatically changed in line with the technological developments. With the advent of transistors, valve-based and electricity-operated radio receivers have transformed into battery-operated receivers. This has enabled radio reception in a portable mode and subsequently in handheld and pocket versions of receivers.

With declining prices, radio receivers were offered as add-on products/features in combination with tape recorders, CD players and clocks as desktop, portable models, car audio and music systems.

Rich content has renewed the interest of listeners with the introduction of private-sector, high-quality FM



Uniwave Di-Wave 100 DRM radio receiver

radio broadcasts in the broadcasting domain. Mobile telephony has received an unprecedented acceptance in the market, transforming India into the fastest growing telecom market in the world.

Of late, FM receivers are being offered in combination with mobile handsets. According to some estimates, almost 50 per cent of the 900 million handsets in operation in the country (by October 2013) have built-in FM radio receivers.

International chipset manufacturers currently offer chipsets for both desktop radios and car radios, and also individual building blocks such as audio decoders, data application/service layer decoders and baseband decoders.

Digitisation of radio broadcasting would enhance the consumer interface, experience of listeners and delivery of content. It will also offer value-added services. Broadcast content and availability of affordable receivers are expected to play a key role in acceptance of the DRM digital radio services by the masses. India with its large reposi-

tory of qualified manpower in engineering, technology and management has attracted a number of Fortune 500 companies to set up R&D bases in the country.

Indian manpower is known for creativity, lateral thinking capability and, above all, frugal/value engineering. India is acknowledged to be the second largest market in the world in terms of its potential and is one of the fastest growing markets for electronics in the world.

The National Policy on Electronics (NPE) 2012 shares the vision to create a globally competitive electronics design and manufacturing industry to meet the country's need and serve the international markets. The policy provides several incentives for encouraging R&D, manufacturing and exports.

India so far is the largest and the most diverse market adopting digital radio based on the DRM standard. Incidentally, India is also a price-sensitive market. For the radio services to fulfil the objective of informing, educating and entertaining the masses, radio receivers at affordable prices need to be available in the market.

India's transitioning to the digital radio broadcasting based on DRM standard provides business opportunities for design and development, manufacturing of a range of DRM receivers—including low-cost affordable sets for masses—for usage as desktop, car radio/audio systems and integrated/add-ons to the mobile phones for catering to the domestic and export markets.

India can indeed position itself as a global supplier of affordable DRM radio sets in multiple formats. ●

The author retired as senior director, DeIRI, and is now a senior advisor with Confederation of Indian Industry (CII). The views expressed here are in his personal capacity